even won seats. Disgracefully, the NLD and its Rakhine allies then cooperated with the military to have these victories annulled. Even in 2010, some Rohingyas had the right to vote and three were elected from Rakhine.[6] One of these, Shwe Maung, stood for the USDP. To properly understand the risks of the 2015 electoral cycle we need first to look at how the lead up was used to complete the exclusion of the Rohingyas from civic life in Myanmar, then consider the wider political dynamics in Myanmar as a whole, and then move on to consider the very specific dynamics within Rakhine. There is a risk that tensions at either national or regional level could be the final trigger; however, the complete exclusion of the Rohingyas in effect means that either the authorities reverse their recent decisions or the situation will escalate into forced deportation and/or mass murder.[7] In effect, this has created a situation in which anything can be the final trigger, since any safety nets or alternative power structures have been destroyed.

Exclusion of the Rohingyas

The lead up to the 2015 elections was marked by an escalation of the exclusion of the Rohingyas. As a group, they have been left with no place in civic Myanmar, many have been forced into internal camps, their last vestige of official documentation has been stripped away and there were, for the first time ever, almost no Muslim candidates from any ethnic group,[8] including those outside Rakhine, standing for parliament in 2015.[9]

A key step in bringing this situation about was the census conducted in 2014, when the Rohingya ethnic group was not included, and was expected to self-identify as foreigners. David Mathieson of Human Rights Watch has expressed severe concerns not just about the conduct of the census but also the complicity of the UN and other donors:

> The exclusion of the Rohingya from the census was a betrayal of the very principles and purpose of conducting the census, and the international donors and UN agencies who were involved are complicit in this exclusion. The Rohingya have the right to self-identify and should be accorded the rights of citizens. The census [in] refusing to do so doesn't solve the problem of stateless Rohingya, it exacerbates it and the government shouldn't be caving to extremists and their racist agendas.[10]

The 2014 census[11] saw the deliberate exclusion of the Rohingyas, as they were forced to choose to register either as 'Bengalis' or be excluded.